

ALASKA SPORTSMAN: THE HEALING POWER OF SALTWATER

Alaska

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Sprint Dogs
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MY VIEW NORTH

SPRINT

by Andy Hall

LONG, LONG AGO, before the Iditarod Trail Sled Dog Race brought long-distance sled dog racing to international attention, sprint dog racing was the sport that grabbed Alaska's attention each winter.

The events were a little rougher around the edges than today's long-distance races. Then again, that could describe most of Alaska then. Sure, there were big names like Gareth Wright, Earl Norris and Carl Huntington, as well known in their day as Martin Buser, Jeff King and Lance Mackey are today. But there was an everyman quality to the sport that doesn't exist in the long-distance events that dominate today. It was a feeling that someone could walk in off the street—or, more accurately out of the village—and win.

George Attla did it in 1958 when he turned the mushing world on its ear by winning the Fur Rendezvous World Championship sled dog race. He hailed from Huslia, the Koyukuk River village that was home to the venerable Huntington, but nothing else hinted that he might be the champion who would dominate the sport for the next four decades.

This was before dependable snowmobiles existed and when air travel was still a little sketchy in Alaska. Dogs still played a key role in village life, and a would-be racer could train his team while eking out a subsistence existence away from the limelight.

Those days are gone, but sprint mushing—though it has been overshadowed in recent years by the Iditarod and the Yukon Quest—might be making a comeback. While working dogs have become rare in rural Alaska, sprint teams seem to be springing up

around the state. The dogs look different than the champs of Attla's day: They're houndy, long-legged animals, bred for speed rather than endurance. Instead of working teams rising out of rural Alaska, the new racers come from the road system communities. Visit Tozier track in Anchorage, or the Beach Lake trails in Chugiak on a winter weekend, and alongside veteran racers you'll see families training for and competing in the small races that require just one-, two- and three-dog teams—the kind of racing that is accessible to the average person.

The Iditarod is still the Last Great Race and the Yukon Quest is arguably the toughest, but the Fur Rendezvous Open World Championship is grabbing its share of the spotlight. This year, Iditarod veterans Aaron Burmeister and Ryan Redington, following Jeff King's 2010 example, have signed up. And Dee Dee Jonrowe is rumored to be considering giving it a go.

The championship promises to be exciting, but I'll be watching the kids racing in the one-, two- and three-dog heats and wondering if a future champ is already there on the runners, hailing from the Bush like Attla, or perhaps from the modern landscape that has encroached onto the Last Frontier and is producing a new breed of musher.

Andy Hall

SPEED **RACERS**

Sprint dogs are the lesser-known—
and much faster—stars of mushing

By T.C. Mitchell



Excited dogs lead
a team in the Open
North American
Championship Sled
Dog Race, one of
the world's premiere
sprint races, held
annually in Fairbanks.

THE IDITAROD TRAIL SLED DOG RACE has gained national—even global—attention over its 39 years. It has a romantic history based in the struggle to transport diphtheria serum to Nome during an outbreak of the disease in 1925.

Its top competitors are celebrities in Alaska. TV shows have been made about the race, and spectators travel from around the world each March to witness the event.

But there are other mushers in Alaska—and around the world—who compete in a far different kind of race. Theirs is all about speed. It doesn't have the popularity or allure of the Iditarod, but some of the Iditarod's top names are starting to take notice of sprint racing.

THE WIND IN YOUR HAIR

The iconic image of a long-distance dog race like the Iditarod or Yukon Quest is a lone musher and his team silhouetted against a great, white expanse of snow. But mention the names of top-level sprint races like the Open World and Open North American championships, and fans will picture a dog team zipping around a curve on a trail in the woods, with a musher barely hanging onto the back of the speeding, tilting sled. Sprint racing is less about grit and determination, and more about action and excitement.

After three decades and 150,000 miles of running long-distance dog teams in races like the Iditarod and the 1,000-mile Yukon Quest, four-time Iditarod winner Jeff King decided he wanted to try the faster style of racing. He leased a sprint-racing dog team from top sprint musher Blayne "Buddy" Streeter, and hit the trail in Anchorage last winter for the 2010 Fur Rendezvous Open World Championship Sled Dog Race.

What was the attraction? "Going like hell," King said. "The wind in your hair." He has experienced that kind of speed—nearly 30 mph—on occasion during long races, but not for a sustained distance. Endurance dogs like the ones King raises and races can't keep up that pace.

King did well for a first-timer, finishing in fourth

place at the end of the three-days of 25-mile heat races and winning about \$7,300. And he enjoyed himself in a way that just isn't possible on the back of a long-distance sled because, no matter how similar the mushing styles may look the same to the uninitiated, they are drastically different sports.

A DIFFERENT KIND OF DOG

Just as a 100-meter dash and a marathon make different demands on the human athlete, sprint races such as the Open World Championship Race and the Open North American Championship, and long-distance mushing like the Iditarod and the Yukon Quest International Sled Dog Race, require

very different training methods and put unique demands on dogs. (See "From Trapline to Finish Line" on Page 31 for details and the history of sled-dog racing in Alaska.)

Sprint racing teams are generally smaller, usually with six to 10 dogs in harness, depending on the race specifications. Because they are not going to be spending days on remote trails, mushers are not required to carry food or survival equipment, so their sleds are lighter and faster. And while long-distance teams generally trot at a brisk pace for hours at a time, day after day, sprint teams give it all they have, running as fast as possible along a much shorter course.

"Distance racing dogs, while working for hours on end, generally work between 40 and 60 percent of their maximal capacity," Dr. Arleigh Reynolds, an Alaska veterinarian and senior scientist for Nestlé Purina, explained in an article published on the Fur Rondy website.

But sprint-racing dogs maintain intensities of about 90 percent of maximum, for about 90 minutes, Reynolds wrote. He compared sprint dogs with Tour de France champion Lance Armstrong. The rate of oxygen use by sprint dogs is about three times that of Armstrong during a bicycle race.

"I tell people this is why we ride on the sled and they pull it," Reynolds wrote.

• A sprint team competes in a 12-mile race on the ice near Kotzebue. Long-distance dog teams trot at a brisk pace for hours at a time, day after day, but sprint teams run as fast as possible along a much shorter course.





long
distance
dog



sprint
mushing
dog

● **Sprint and endurance mushers** select and breed their dogs for traits essential to their styles of racing, and the resulting dogs are often noticeably different (ABOVE), and a recent study concluded that dogs bred and trained for one type of mushing cannot easily be used for the other. The ideal endurance dog is larger and more heavily muscled, with a higher percentage of malamute and husky in its bloodline, while the ideal sprint dog is smaller, lighter and leaner.

Sprint dogs also need more fast-twitch muscle fibers than their endurance counterparts, said Dr. Stuart Nelson, chief Iditarod veterinarian. Fast-twitch fibers are much better at generating short bursts of strength or speed than slow-twitch muscles but they fatigue more quickly. Every mammal has both types, but different training techniques will result in one type being more predominant.

Another difference is the dogs' caloric intake. Sprint dogs are generally smaller, lighter dogs. Distance dogs burn 10,000 or more calories a day, but sprint dogs burn less than half that amount on average, Nelson said.

The dogs also have slight genetic differences. Thomas Swan, a recreational musher from Two Rivers who has done extensive research on mushing, said sprint-racing dogs originated not from the freight-hauling dogs of the Arctic but in the villages of the boreal region of Canada and the United States, when Native North Americans began using dogs along traplines after European fur traders arrived.

"There is no historical evidence to show that Native American or First Nations people of the boreal regions routinely used dogs to draw sleds prior to the introduction of the European fur trade," Swan said. "Eskimo dogs have been selected for hauling freight on sleds for at least 4,000 years. The best available evidence indicates that Indians did not adopt dog mushing from Eskimo people."

Rather, the use of sled dogs became common in the Great Lakes region in the late 17th century, in the Northwest Territories of Canada in the late 18th century and in Interior Alaska in the mid 19th century, Swan said.

The two types of dogs emerged from the same genetic base, Swan said, and shared the features of prick ears, a double coat and a curling tail, but were selected for different traits based on the tasks for which they were used.

"Originally, the dogs of boreal Natives were

selected for traits that made them better dogs for hunting and packing," Swan said. "Hence, they were leaner, longer-legged and rangier than the dogs that arctic villagers selected with traits that made better freight pulling dogs."

"Historical descriptions of sled dogs invariably describe the Indian dogs as being similar in appearance to wolves or foxes," according to Swan's research, "with emphasis on a long legs, rangy appearance and pointed snout. Meanwhile the dogs of coastal Eskimo people were, and are, dissimilar to wolves or foxes due to a stockier build, broader skull and shorter muzzle."

BRED FOR IT

When people began to race dogs seriously in the 20th century, the incentive to select dogs for their preferred characteristics increased dramatically. Today, sprint and endurance mushers select and breed for traits essential to their styles of racing, and the resulting dogs are noticeably different.

In July 2010, Heather Huson, a genetic research graduate student at the National Human Genome Research Institute, part of the National Institutes of Health in Bethesda, Md., and who is also associated with Institute of Arctic Biology at the University of Alaska, Fairbanks. Huson published a research paper examining the various dog breeds that have been brought into sprint and endurance mushing bloodlines in the last century and the characteristics they have lent to today's canine athletes.

In the study, Huson, who has also been breeding and racing sprint dogs for 25 years, worked with several colleagues to sample sled dogs from eight kennels, rating them for speed, endurance and work ethic. These attributes were correlated with genetic information taken from each dog and compared to likely ancestor breeds. Huson's research revealed that Alaskan malamute and Siberian husky are found in higher percentages in elite endurance dogs, Saluki and Anatolian shepherd lines have provided both distance and sprint dogs with additional speed. The distance dogs she studied that displayed a higher work ethic tended to have more Anatolian shepherd, a breed known as a large, powerful and



EXHAUSTED: MAREK ILLUSTRATION; JAMES GOODMAN; THIS AND JAMES GOODMAN

● **Exhausted dogs** take a rest at the end of a sprint race. Sprint dogs use about three times the rate of oxygen used by Lance Armstrong during a bicycle race.



PHOTO: LEFT: BRADLEY A. HART/ALASKAPOST.COM; PHOTO TOP RIGHT: PATRICK J. DORR/ALASKAPOST.COM



● A police officer stops traffic to let a dog team cross College Road in Fairbanks during the Open North American Championship sled dog race.

● Buddy Streeper and his team race along the Chester Creek trail during the Fur Rendezvous World Championship Sled Dog Race in Anchorage.

independent livestock guardian.

"The Anatolian shepherd's breed description of loyalty, independence and hardiness portray a breed of similar character and strength to that of the distance sled dogs," according to Huson's report, which was published in an online issue of the journal *BMC Genetics*.

Huson's team also found evidence of pointer, Saluki, Borzoi and Weimaraner in the dogs they studied, but concluded that selective breeding hasn't always provided the characteristics breeders were seeking.

"Interestingly, the pointer, which has been repeatedly bred into the sprint dogs in recent years with the idea of enhancing speed, was not found to positively affect speed performance," the report stated.

Huson's team concluded that the genetic profiles of sprint and distance dogs are significant enough that dogs bred and trained for one type of mushing cannot easily be used for the other.

"We speculate that a fraction of the dogs competitive in sprint racing are genetically capable of performing as distance dogs, but the reverse is not true," the research report concluded.

Iditarod winner Jeff King agrees.

"The training would be foreign to them," King said, when asked if he could use his long-distance teams to race sprints in future. "It would take some major training."

THE ALASKA SPRINT SCENE

Specialized breeding and training is displayed at the two major sprint races held in Alaska each year: the Open World Championship Race held during the Fur Rendezvous each February in Anchorage,



▼ **Andy Huetten** and his dogs (ABOVE) display the classic image of a sprint mushing team during the 2007 Open North American Championship sled dog race: a sled zipping around a curve on a trail, the musher barely hanging on to the sled.

▼ **A musher gives his sled an extra push** (LEFT). Sprint mushers are not required to carry food or survival equipment in their sled bags, so the sleds are lighter and faster than those of long-distance mushers.

FROM TRAPLINE TO FINISH LINE

MANY PEOPLE BELIEVE sled-dog racing dates back centuries. Susan Duck, executive director of the Anchorage Fur Rendezvous festival, said its roots are in remote villages where dogs were used for transporting goods and people between communities, or along traplines or hunting trails. The concept of racing these working dogs likely arose when one musher asserted to another: My dogs can beat your dogs.

"It all started with working dogs," Duck said. "In the cold, it was better to have fast teams than slow teams."

Archaeological evidence puts the earliest use of sled dogs in the circumpolar region at more than 4,000 years ago, according to Tim White, a musher and amateur historian from Minnesota who has written several articles on mushing for the International Federation of Sled Dog Sports. White said some anthropologists have suggested that human habitation and survival in the Arctic would not have been possible without sled dogs to help with hauling and make long-distance travel faster and safer.

White said the first written account of a race was an informal challenge between travelers on the route from Winnipeg, Manitoba, to St. Paul, Minn., in the 1850s. In 1886, the first St. Paul Winter Carnival featured sled dog races to highlight the attractions of winter in Minnesota.

The first major long-distance sled dog race in the world—the All Alaska Sweepstakes—began in 1908. Organized by the Nome Kennel Club, teams mushed 408 miles from Nome to Candia and back for a small purse, using mainly freighting dogs.

Interest in racing waned as World War I arrived but, in 1925, the famous Iditarod trail diphtheria serum run made Alaska's mushers famous worldwide after 20 mushers teamed up to transport the serum between Nenana and Nome in 129.5 hours. Musher Leonhard Seppala then went south and helped popularize racing in New England. The 1932 Lake Placid Winter Olympic Games included sprint racing as a demonstration sport. The contestants ran seven-dog teams 25 miles each day for two days.

A small group of interested participants continued racing both sprints and long distances in Alaska and the Lower 48 without much interest from the public. In 1935, the Fur Rondy Festival began, featuring a children's sled-dog race down Fourth Avenue in Anchorage. The Open World Championship Race and the Open North American Championship both debuted in 1946. But it was the creation of the Iditarod Trail Sled Dog Race in 1973, (followed in 1984 by the first Yukon Quest International Sled Dog Race between Fairbanks and Whitehorse, Yukon) that really brought about a resurgence of dog mushing in Alaska and made the rest of the United States and the world take notice. Today, there are numerous well-known short- and middle-distance races in Alaska, Canada, the Lower 48 and Scandinavia each winter.

and the Open North American Championship, held in March in Fairbanks. Both are run in a series of three 20- to 30-mile heats over three days, and both draw some of the fastest teams from around the world. But the two courses are quite different.

The Open North American starts in town, but the trail quickly takes mushers into the quiet of the woods. Anchorage's race is run within the city limits on streets and popular trails, and the course is lined with fans from start to finish. Both courses are run each day for three days, with the cumulative times determining the winner.

Blayne "Buddy" Streeper has run both, and prefers the excitement and fan-friendly atmosphere of the Rondy. He says the Rondy is technically different from Fairbanks and requires more concentration. "There are a lot of distractions for the dogs, but it's also good to hear the crowd," he said. "It's exciting."

The Fort Nelson, British Columbia, musher's thinking might also be influenced by the fact that in 2010 he won the race for the fourth consecutive time and sixth overall, ranking him third behind only the legendary George Attia with 10 wins and Roland Lombard with eight victories.

Iditarod musher Jeff King won't be on the sprint courses this year. He called his sprint race experience a novelty and an expensive one, so he wouldn't commit to future races. Leasing Streeper's dog team cost him \$10,000. "That was about 95 percent of the cost I incurred," he said. "The rest went to entry fee, transportation."

Instead, King plans to be in Norway helping with a race. And he won't be in this year's 2011 Iditarod, either. But as sprint mushing piques the interest of more long-distance competitors, the field may become more interesting. A few of King's former Iditarod competitors, including DeeDee Jonrowe and Aaron Burmeister, have indicated they may participate in Alaska sprint races this year.

Only time will tell if Alaska sprint mushing will gain the popularity that long-distance mushing has enjoyed in recent years, but the dogs will keep on doing what comes naturally. ■

T.C. Mitchell is former editor of the *Mat-Su Valley Frontiersman*.

TOP PHOTO: BILLYE ENGLISH/ALASKA TODAY; BOTTOM PHOTO: JAMES WILSON